



# Merge the Union

*Break the ice. Break the map.*

## Merge the Union

### Merge the Union — Team Icebreaker

**Merge the Union** — an icebreaker where democracy meets questionable geography. Each round, vote one state off the map. A neighboring state absorbs it, gets a new mashup name, and the United States become a bit more united.

*Break the ice. Break the map.*

**Hosting a Brown Bag?** Use the [Merge the Union — Host Guide](#) doc. It has a sample script, recommended settings for a 15-minute slot, and facilitation tips.

**Estimated time:** 15–25 minutes for a 50-state run, or break it across multiple meetings with the session timer and save feature. Shorter if you turn on random events (like a Civil War that can undo your progress).

[Download the Game](#)

[Download the Optional Tracker Sheet](#)

### Opening the game

1. Click **Download the Game** above.
2. Find the downloaded file in your **Downloads** folder — it's called `merge-the-union-browser.html`.
3. Double-click it to open in your browser. (Or right-click → *Open with* → Chrome / Safari / Edge.)

⚠ **First load takes 1–2 minutes.** The game fetches US map data from the internet on first open. Subsequent opens are instant — bookmark it after the first load and you're good.

## How to play

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1. Share your screen and open the game.
2. Configure the **Spice settings** popup at start (players, timer, events, win mode, Historical Hijinks, free merge mode, music, session length) — or click *Skip* for casual play.
3. The team decides which state to eliminate (out loud, in chat, or via Tally voting).
4. Click that state on the map.
5. Pick which state absorbs it from the modal.
6. A new mega-state name is generated. Hit **Continue**, **Try a different name**, or type your own.
7. Repeat until one mega-state remains. The final winner depends on the win mode you picked.

## Tips for running it as an icebreaker

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- Share your screen before starting and pre-load the page so the map is already drawn.
- Pick a **win mode** that fits the group size. Small group (3–6) → Champion or Survivor. Big group (8+) → Team Conquest. Casual works for any size.
- Set **Session length** to 15 minutes if the icebreaker is squeezed into a Brown Bag — the game auto-saves when time's up.
- Type team or player names so the turn-rotation pill shows whose pick is up.
- Keep the timer **off** for the first round so people can warm up. Turn it on later if energy lags.
- Adjust the music volume before the meeting starts so it's background-energy, not center-stage.
- Let people *defend* a state before it's eliminated — that's where the comedy comes from.
- Read every mega-state name out loud. *Especially* the bad ones.
- Pair with the **tracker companion** on a second monitor so you can read each state's snarky description as it's voted off.
- Screenshot the winner screen and share in Slack.

## Setup options

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### Win modes

Set at game start via Spice settings. Default is **Casual** (no winner — just vibes).

| Mode                       | How you win                                                                                                             | Setup required                          |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| <b>Casual</b>              | No winner. Play for the absurd mega-state names.                                                                        | Nothing.                                |
| <b>Champion the Anchor</b> | 50 states distributed randomly to players. Winner: whoever owns the <i>anchor</i> of the final mega-state.              | Player names.                           |
| <b>Team Conquest</b>       | States distributed across 2–4 colored teams. Winner: team that owns the final anchor.                                   | Team list (see below).                  |
| <b>Survivor Points</b>     | 1 point per round each of your states stays independent. +10 points if you own the final anchor. Highest score wins.    | Player names.                           |
| <b>Pure Prediction</b>     | Before the game, each player picks the state they think will be the final anchor. Winners: everyone whose pick matched. | Player names + Name: State predictions. |

### Team Conquest setup format

Free-form textarea — each line is a team. Members optional after a colon:

```
Marketing: Marquette, Alex
Engineering: Sam, Pat
Sales: Jordan
```

Up to 4 teams. If members are listed, they become the per-round turn rotation automatically.

### Voting mode

| Mode               | How it works                                                            | Use when                                         |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Quick Merge</b> | One click eliminates the state immediately.                             | The group has already decided verbally.          |
| <b>Tally Votes</b> | Clicks add a vote tally. Hit Tally Votes again to eliminate the leader. | Driver enters group votes; ties broken randomly. |

## Spice settings

- **Win mode** — see table above.
- **Player names** — One per line. Drives turn rotation (the “whose pick” pill next to the round counter).
- **30-second round timer** — Optional. Auto-eliminates a random state on timeout. Ticks audibly in the last 7 seconds.
- **Session length** — Total time budget. 5 / 10 / 15 / 30 minutes or no limit. Auto-saves when it hits zero.
- **Random events** — Enabled by default. ~18% chance per round from round 4 on.
- **Historical Hijinks** — Enabled by default. Draws a history-inspired card every 3 rounds.
- **Free merge mode** — Any state can absorb any other — no adjacency required. Great for geography-challenged groups.
- **Background music** — Enabled by default. Starts as soon as you click *Start*.

## Save & resume

Built for the “5 minutes at the top of stand-up” model — set a time budget, play, save when the timer’s up, resume next time.

- **Session length** in Spice settings: *No limit, 5 / 10 / 15 / 30 minutes*. A status card shows the live countdown and pulses warning color in the final minute.
- **Auto-save on timeout** — when the session clock hits zero, the game saves automatically and the Save / Load modal opens with that save highlighted.
- **Named multi-save** — Save / Load button opens a list of every save with name, round, mega-state count, and timestamp. Resume or delete per item.
- **Custom names** — Type a name like “Tuesday standup” before hitting Save. Leave blank to default to “Game Jun 11 at 1:34 PM”. Duplicates auto-rename to “(2)” / “(3)”.
- **Auto-resume prompt** — When the page loads with saves present, the Save / Load modal opens automatically.
- **Cross-device transfer** — Advanced section exports/imports a save as JSON. Good for picking up on a different computer.

## Special features

### Historical Hijinks

Optional mode that draws a history-inspired event card every 3 rounds. Defaults are “safe workplace icebreaker” — low/medium impact only, require confirmation, max 6 cards per game, no repeats. High-chaos cards are disabled by default.

Each card has a **title**, **tiny fact**, **effect**, and **flavor line**. The team can **Apply Hijink** or **Skip**. All draws are logged in the Merge Log with a lavender badge. Toggle on/off mid-game with the ⚡ **Hijinks** button in the controls panel.

| Card                           | Effect                                                                  |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Louisiana Purchase</b>      | The next winning state absorbs two neighbors instead of one.            |
| <b>First State Advantage</b>   | Delaware ignores its first elimination attempt.                         |
| <b>Gold Rush</b>               | California gets temporary protection for one round.                     |
| <b>Route 66</b>                | Route 66 states are treated as connected for merge purposes (flavor).   |
| <b>Tiny but Loud</b>           | Rhode Island can't lose unless it loses by more than one vote (flavor). |
| <b>West Virginia Breakaway</b> | If WV has been absorbed, it returns as an independent state.            |
| <b>Space Race</b>              | Florida, Texas, or Alabama gets temporary protection for one round.     |
| <b>Oregon Trail</b>            | Oregon gets temporary protection for one round.                         |
| <b>Recount!</b>                | If the next vote is decided by one vote, redo it (flavor).              |
| <b>Florida Man Event</b>       | High-chaos card. Disabled by default.                                   |

## Random events

A separate event system — ~18% chance per round from round 4 on. Enabled by default in Spice settings.

| Event              | What happens                                                                            |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Earthquake</b>  | A random state is eliminated. The map physically shakes. Team still picks the absorber. |
| ✕ <b>Civil War</b> | The largest mega-state loses a rebel state, which secedes back to independence.         |
| <b>Defection</b>   | A border state switches sides and joins a neighboring mega-state.                       |

## Sound & music

Two audio controls in the top-right corner:

- **sound-effects toggle** — Mutes/unmutes the whoosh, drumroll, ding, fanfare, and timer ticks.

- **music play/pause + volume slider** — Plays a custom 35-second loop (“Sunday High Score”) embedded in the file so it works offline. Auto-starts when you dismiss Spice settings.

## Winner screen

- **Mode result block** calls out who won (“Marquetta wins with 47 pts!” / “Red Team wins!” / “Alex called it!”).
- The mega-state’s final name appears as a giant Bungee headline.
- Below it: a **flag emoji**, **national motto**, **national bird**, and the first line of a **national anthem** — all generated from curated templates.
- Full list of every original state inside the empire.

## Reference

### Controls

| Control                        | What it does                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Tally Votes</b> (primary)   | Switches to tally mode; if already in tally mode and votes exist, eliminates the top-voted state |
| <b>Quick Merge</b> (secondary) | Switches to quick mode (click a state to eliminate instantly)                                    |
| Clear Votes                    | Reset the tally (tally mode only)                                                                |
| Undo Merge                     | Roll back the last elimination                                                                   |
| <b>New Game</b>                | Re-opens Spice settings to reconfigure modes, teams, and options before starting fresh           |
| ⌵ Hijinks: On / Off            | Toggle Historical Hijinks on or off mid-game without restarting                                  |
| <b>Save / Load Game</b>        | Open the named saves manager — list, resume, name, delete, or copy/paste as text                 |
| button                         | Mute/unmute all sound effects                                                                    |
| button                         | Play / pause the looping background music                                                        |
| Music volume slider            | Adjust music volume (0–100%)                                                                     |
| Try a different name           | Re-roll the merged mega-state name                                                               |
| Write your own name            | Type whatever the group shouts out, hit Enter                                                    |

## Game files

**Standalone game** — `merge-the-union-browser.html` . Real US state shapes (Albers projection, AK and HI as insets). Mega-state names from a curated template pool. Single self-contained file. Needs internet on first load.

**Cowork artifact** — `merge-the-union.html` . Tile-grid US map. Mega-state names generated by Claude live each round. Winner lore also Claude-generated. Opens in the Cowork sidebar.

**Tracker companion** — `merge-the-union-tracker.html` . All 50 states listed with snarky descriptions. Click to mark eliminated; fades + drops to the bottom. Click again to bring back. Pair on a second monitor for “obituary” beats.

## Changelog

- **State abbreviation labels** — Two-letter state codes now appear on every state in the map.
- **Free merge mode** — New Spice setting: any state can absorb any other with no adjacency requirement.
- **New Game button** — “Start Over” renamed to “New Game” and re-opens the Spice settings screen.
- **In-session Hijinks toggle** — ✂ button in the Controls panel to turn Historical Hijinks on or off mid-game.
- **Host Guide** — Separate Google Doc for Brown Bag facilitators.
- **Tracker companion** — New `merge-the-union-tracker.html` file: all 50 states with snarky descriptions.
- **Multi-save with custom names** — Named saves with resume / delete / JSON export.
- **Session timer** — 5 / 10 / 15 / 30 minute time budget with auto-save on timeout.
- **Save / Load Game button** — Named saves manager with JSON copy/paste cross-device.
- **Browser tab favicon** — Cream-and-navy puzzle-button logo.
- **Background music** — “Sunday High Score” 35-second loop with play/pause + volume slider.
- **Historical Hijinks** — 10-card history-themed event deck.
- **Map jazz** — Smooth color cross-fade on absorption, earthquake shake, final-two spotlight.
- **4 win modes** — Champion the Anchor, Team Conquest, Survivor Points, Pure Prediction.
- **Random events** — Earthquake, Civil War, Defection.
- **Round timer + player turn rotation, Winner lore, Custom name override, Bungee font.**
- **Rebrand** from “Last State Standing” to **Merge the Union**.

*Built with Cowork ♥*